Pine Valley Special Services District

Pine Valley Fire Station, 680 E. Main St., Conference Room

Meeting Minutes

May 7, 2025

Attending Board Members: Mary Esther Putnam, Chairwoman; Bob Dalley, Vice-Chairman; Allen Cannon; Emily Neilson; Steve Shakespeare
Attending PVSSD Assistants: Rick Peetz, Clerk; LaDawn Christensen, Treasurer
Fire Chief: Robert Hardy
Guests Attending: Rob Nodine, Brian Davis, Claudia Davis

A. Welcome: Mary Esther called the meeting to order.

B. June Meeting Minutes: Steve moved to approve the June meeting minutes. Allen seconded the motion, and all were in favor.

C. June 30th Recovery Fund Meeting Minutes: Emily moved to approve the June meeting minutes. Steve seconded the motion, and all were in favor.

D. Wildland Recover Funds

Mary Esther reported ongoing discussions with the County Attorney regarding donations and tax deductions. While no large donors have come forward at this time, there was past interest from a potential contributor who inquired about tax benefits if the district were classified as a 501(c)(3) organization. The County Attorney advised that although managing individual donations can be complex, contributions used for public benefits, such as fire mitigation, may still qualify as tax-deductible under IRS guidelines. Mary Esther, who made the donation, noted that determining tax deductibility is a matter between her and her accountant.

The goal of the prior discussion was to determine whether the county could accept and manage such donations. She recently followed up with the County Attorney, who had reviewed the tax implications and consulted with the State Emergency Management Board, the County Commission, and others. The consensus was that handling donations on an individual basis is extremely complex and nearly impossible to manage properly. However, they did support the idea of using donations to help with future fire mitigation efforts.

There was some discussion about possible uses for the funds, such as generators or other mitigation equipment. The fire chief confirmed that the fire department has already been restored to operational status and does not currently need funds for recovery. However, he noted that additional equipment to support mitigation could always be useful.

Rick presented a financial summary: $7,778.02 received via Venmo, $12,330 in cash and checks, with $2,330.39 reimbursed to Emily for early fire-related expenses, leaving a balance of $17,777.63. Most donation notes were vague, though some referenced fire, restoration or town. The board agreed that funds should be used in the spirit of restoration and mitigation efforts. Mary Esther asked the guests to give a short suggestion on where the funds should be allocated.

Suggestions included keeping the donated funds within the valley, waiting to determine what insurance will cover, supporting residents without insurance, allocating funds to the fire department that serves the community, directing large donations to those who lost homes, and planting trees.

Steve suggested we advertise that donations are welcome and disclose where the money is being spent. He will contact homeowners who have lost their homes or suffered damage and ask what the community can do to help. Emily suggested a Venmo account for the fire recovery. Allen mentioned a bank account has already been created for donation. Allen made a motion to set up a separate Venmo account specifically for receiving donations titled the "Pine Valley Recovery Fund" and to advertise, Steve seconded the motion, all were in favor.

It was agreed that the donations should be used particularly for fire mitigation and restoration. It was emphasized that using the funds to support efforts like removing burned trees or reducing future fire risk would be appropriate.

E. New Webmaster (Emily) Joseph has been selected as the new webmaster and will begin working with the current webmaster, Vicki, to transition responsibilities.

F. Fire Department Report (Robert)

Chief Hardy presented the June report. The department responded to sixteen calls: twelve EMS calls (four in Pine Valley, and eight in other

locations outside Pine Valley – including Central) and four fire calls, one in Baker Campground and the others in Pine Valley (brush and wildland). He reported 1.228 volunteer hours, 126 training hours, 272 equipment hours, 974 response hours, and 128 'other' hours.

Alan expressed appreciation on behalf of the community for Robert's leadership and the dedication of the fire department, and thanked Robert for his service.

G. Community Center Update (Allen)

Alan reported on the current update the community center property. Ongoing coordination with the county and a recent conversation with Joel Rechsteiner. The property is owned by the Forest Service, and the county is pursuing a potential land trade or purchase. A survey has been completed, and the county is expected to submit a formal proposal to the Forest Service by the end of the month.

H. GRAMA Request Charges – Action Item (Steve)

Emily handed out the proposed updated GRAMA policy in the previous PVLAD board meeting. The proposed changes are that the district may charge for the time necessary for the independent contractor to retrieve and prepare requested documents at a proposed rate per hour after a certain time. The board will adapt the same language as the PVLAD GRAMA policy. Emily recommended adopting the language that was handed out tonight to the board members in the PVLAD, with the insertion of a $25 rate per hour after one hour. Steve seconded, and all were in favor.

I. Clerk Report

Rick reports the financial report for the previous month. He sent out late notices for this year's assessment fees. Steve is asking the board to not charge the 2026 assessment fee for the homes destroyed in the fire. It will be added to next month's agenda.

J. Treasurer Report

LaDawn reported that the financial reconciliation for June. Allen moved to approve both the financial and treasurer report. Emily seconded the motion, and all in favor.

K. Citizen Requests:

Emily summarized the UT HB0048 bill, which shifts wildfire risk assessments to the state or county. Properties in high-risk zones may face new fees, with mitigation efforts helping reduce those fees. Not all properties will be assessed, only those near wildland areas. The county may adapt and developed rules, with community education planned to clarify assessments separate from existing fees. The board emphasized coordinated fire mitigation and the importance of proper home maintenance to reduce fire risk and insurance costs.

The board also discussed sending a formal thank-you to agencies and responders who assisted during the recent fire.

Allen moved to adjourn the meeting, Steve seconded the motion, and all were in favor. The next scheduled PVSSD meeting will be on August 6, 2025.